



Calm Home Skills

Premium practice worksheet

CALM HOME SKILLS - LESSON 04

Make handling predictable before it has to be necessary.

This worksheet helps owners build comfort with touch, restraint, brushing, paw care, and everyday handling so grooming and home care feel safer for everyone.

TRAINER NOTE

Good handling work is about consent, predictability, and short successful reps—not just “getting through it.”

START HERE

Dog: _____

Date: _____

Owner: _____

Best reward: _____

1 What success looks like

By the end of this lesson, the owner can do short handling reps with the dog staying more relaxed and willing, rather than frozen, avoidant, or panicked.

2 Practice plan

1

Touch and feed

Briefly touch an easy area, then feed while your dog stays relaxed.

2

Add tiny duration

Hold or handle for one extra second only if the previous rep stayed easy.

3

Introduce tools gently

Show the brush, touch with it briefly, and reward calm behavior.

4

End before stress builds

Take breaks early instead of waiting for the dog to resist or shut down.



Calm Home Skills

Grooming and Handling Prep

3 Supplies and setup

Supplies needed

- ☐ Soft treats or lick option
- ☐ Brush or grooming tool
- ☐ Towel or non-slip mat
- ☐ A quiet place to work for one to three minutes

Set up before you start

- ☐ Start with body areas your dog already tolerates best.
- ☐ Pair touch with food before adding more duration or intensity.
- ☐ Stop while your dog is still successful.

4 Handling and grooming tracker

Date	Body area/tool	Duration	Body language	What helped	Next step

5 5-day practice micro plan

Day 1

Set baseline

Find the easiest version and keep it calm.

Day 2

Repeat wins

Practice the same setup until it looks smooth.

Day 3

Add one tiny step

Add only one small challenge if yesterday

Day 4

Hold or simplify

If your puppy struggled, make today easier.

Day 5

Review notes

Choose the safest next step from your log.



Calm Home Skills

Grooming and Handling Prep

6 Common mistakes and quick fixes

Common mistakes

- Trying to complete full grooming tasks too soon.
- Moving to sensitive areas without enough easy reps first.
- Ignoring subtle signs of discomfort.
- Using restraint as the main strategy instead of training.

If this happens, try this

- If the dog pulls away, shorten the touch and increase reinforcement.
- If the tool itself worries the dog, spend sessions just pairing the sight of it with treats.
- If paw work is difficult, begin with shoulder or leg touches first and work gradually downward.

7 Ready to progress?

- ☐ I can identify when my dog is comfortable vs. stressed during handling.
- ☐ I know which body area is easiest to start with.
- ☐ I am keeping sessions short and winnable.
- ☐ I have a realistic next step for the next session.

HOMEWORK

Complete three short handling sessions this week focused on one easy body area and one grooming tool. Record the best rep and where your dog started to get unsure.

8 Owner reflection

Biggest win: _____

What made it easier: _____

What should I repeat tomorrow: _____

QUESTIONS FOR YOUR FITDOG TRAINER

What should I make easier? _____

What should I practice again? _____

What is the next realistic step? _____